ilo: Product Requirements Document (PRD)

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Audience: Coding agent and product owner. **Status:** Source of truth once the open decisions in Section 16 are resolved.

Conventions used in this document

- **[A#]** marks an assumption. I made it to keep moving, and you can override it.
- **[D#]** marks a decision that needs your approval before the coding agent builds that part. All are listed in Section 16.
- **FR-x / NFR-x** are requirement IDs, so the agent can reference them in tasks and commits.
- **MUST / SHOULD / MAY** have their standard meanings. MUST items are MVP-blocking.

1. Product Summary

ilo is a web-based student counselling and mental wellness platform for educational institutions in India. It lets students reach a counsellor quickly and privately. It gives counsellors one place to manage their caseload. It gives institutions anonymised visibility into whether their counselling service is working.

One-line pitch: an affordable, lightweight counselling platform for institutions that existing premium players weren't built for.

2. Problem Statement

Students often don't get adequate psychological support. Institutions typically have one overloaded counsellor for thousands of students, or none at all. Counselling is often treated as a compliance checkbox for UGC/CBSE mandates rather than a resourced service. Existing platforms (e.g., YourDOST, BRDS, SILICA) are built around high-touch consulting or premium pricing, so smaller or budget-constrained institutions have no suitable option.

Root cause (from 5 Whys analysis): the market lacks a lightweight, affordable counselling platform designed for institutions with thin per-student budgets.

Problems ilo solves in the MVP

#	Problem	Who feels it
P1	Students hesitate to seek help because of stigma, unclear process, or long waits	Students
P2	Counsellors lose time on scheduling, follow-ups, and paper notes	Counsellors
P3	Institutions can't show that counselling is accessible or used, which matters for mandates and accreditation	Admins
P4	Crisis cases have no reliable, fast escalation path	All

3. Value Proposition

- **Students:** a private, low-friction way to reach a real counsellor, with a clear and safe path to help.
- **Counsellors:** a single workspace for appointments, conversations, and session notes, so they can serve more students with the same time.
- **Institutions:** a compliant, affordable counselling service with anonymised utilisation insights.

Differentiation: price and weight (lightweight, fast to deploy), plus a compliance-first design for the DPDP Act 2023.

4. Target Users and Market

4.1 Market focus

- **[D1] Go-to-market conflict to resolve.** Your project notes say you're starting with IITs (Tier-1, where you have access) and expanding later. The original 5 Whys positioning says Tier-2/3 is the core wedge. This PRD **assumes the MVP is piloted at IIT BHU / IIT-type institutions** because of access, while the product is designed to stay lightweight and cheap enough for Tier-2/3. Please confirm.
- **[A1]** MVP users are **18 or older**. IIT students are almost entirely adults, which means **verifiable parental consent for minors is out of MVP scope** (see Section 12).

4.2 Personas (from existing persona work)

Persona	Role	Primary need in MVP
The Overwhelmed Achiever	Student	Quick, discreet access to a counsellor during high-pressure periods
The Quietly Struggling Student	Student	A low-stigma first step that doesn't require a face-to-face walk-in
The Career-Undecided First-Gen Student	Student	Guidance and resources on academic and career direction
The Overloaded Counsellor	Counsellor	Less admin; clear view of who needs attention

Secondary user: Institution Admin (Dean of Students, Head of Counselling Cell). They need aggregate, anonymised reporting and counsellor management.

5. Roles and Permissions

Role	Description
Student	Verified institutional user who seeks counselling
Counsellor	Licensed or authorised counsellor assigned to an institution
Institution Admin	Manages counsellors and views aggregate analytics for their institution only
Platform Admin	Internal ilo team member. Onboards institutions and manages support. **No access to message content or session notes.**

Permission matrix

Capability	Student	Counsellor	Inst. Admin	Platform Admin
Sign in with institutional identity	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
View/edit own profile	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Book/cancel own appointment	Yes	No	No	No
Manage own availability	No	Yes	No	No
View own conversations	Yes	Yes (assigned students only)	No	No
Write/read session notes	No	Yes (own notes only)	No	No
Submit mood check-in	Yes	No	No	No
View a student's check-in history	Own only	Assigned students who consented	No	No
View aggregate, anonymised analytics	No	No	Yes (own institution)	Yes (all, aggregate)
Add/deactivate counsellors	No	No	Yes (own institution)	Yes
Create institutions / invite admins	No	No	No	Yes
Download or delete own data	Yes	No	No	No
Access to crisis-flag details	No	Yes (assigned)	No (count only)	No

Rule: access is enforced at the database level (row-level security), not just in the UI. See NFR-3.

6. Core User Journeys

J1. Student: first-time onboarding and booking

1. Student opens ilo and signs in with their institutional email.
2. Student reads a short privacy explanation and gives consent for data processing.
3. Student completes a minimal profile (preferred name, year or programme, concern categories).
4. Student sees available counsellors and slots, then books one.
5. Student gets a confirmation and reminder.
6. At the session time, the student joins via the meeting link or goes to the in-person location shown.

J2. Student: async message to a counsellor

1. Student opens Messages and starts a conversation with their assigned or chosen counsellor.
2. Counsellor receives a notification and replies within the stated response window.
3. Student receives a notification of the reply.

J3. Student: mood check-in and resources

1. Student submits a quick mood check-in.
2. Student sees relevant self-help resources.
3. If the check-in indicates high risk, the crisis flow triggers (J5).

J4. Counsellor: daily workflow

1. Counsellor signs in and sees today's appointments and unread messages.
2. Counsellor opens a student's record, reviews the history, and runs the session.
3. Counsellor writes a private session note and marks the session complete.
4. Counsellor optionally schedules a follow-up.

J5. Crisis escalation

1. A risk trigger occurs (a student taps "I need help now," or a check-in meets the high-risk rule).
2. The student immediately sees emergency helplines and instructions.

3. The assigned counsellor (or the on-duty counsellor) gets an urgent alert.
4. Counsellor follows the institution's crisis protocol and records the outcome.
5. The legal basis for any disclosure is the medical-emergency exception under DPDP (see Section 12).

J6. Institution Admin: oversight

1. Admin signs in and sees the aggregate dashboard.
2. Admin adds or deactivates counsellors.
3. Admin exports an anonymised utilisation report for compliance or accreditation purposes.

7. User Stories

Student

- **US-S1:** As a student, I want to sign in with my college email so that I don't have to create new credentials.
- **US-S2:** As a student, I want to understand how my data is used before I share anything so that I can trust the service.
- **US-S3:** As a student, I want to see available counsellors and times so that I can book without back-and-forth.
- **US-S4:** As a student, I want to message a counsellor privately so that I can start without a live session.
- **US-S5:** As a student, I want to reschedule or cancel an appointment so that my plans can change.
- **US-S6:** As a student, I want to log my mood quickly so that I can track how I'm doing.
- **US-S7:** As a student, I want to find emergency help instantly so that I'm safe in a crisis.
- **US-S8:** As a student, I want to download or delete my data so that I stay in control.

Counsellor

- **US-C1:** As a counsellor, I want to set my availability so that students can only book real slots.
- **US-C2:** As a counsellor, I want to see my day on one screen so that I can prepare quickly.

- **US-C3:** As a counsellor, I want to write private session notes so that I maintain continuity of care.
- **US-C4:** As a counsellor, I want urgent alerts for high-risk students so that I can act fast.
- **US-C5:** As a counsellor, I want to reply to student messages in one inbox so that nothing gets missed.

Institution Admin

- **US-A1:** As an admin, I want to add or deactivate counsellor accounts so that access reflects staffing.
- **US-A2:** As an admin, I want anonymised usage figures so that I can show the service is working.
- **US-A3:** As an admin, I want an exportable summary so that I can attach it to compliance documents.

Platform Admin

- **US-P1:** As the ilo team, I want to onboard a new institution and invite its first admin so that pilots can start without engineering help.

8. Features and Functional Requirements

8.1 Authentication and Account

- **FR-1 (MUST):** Users sign in using institutional email. **[D2]** Method: email magic link or OTP versus Google/Microsoft SSO. Assumption: **email magic link/OTP via Supabase Auth**, restricted to the institution's registered email domain(s).
- **FR-2 (MUST):** On first sign-in, the user's role is determined by an invitation or the institution's domain. Students self-register. Counsellors and admins must be invited.
- **FR-3 (MUST):** Users can sign out and view or edit basic profile fields.
- **FR-4 (MUST):** Deactivated users cannot sign in, and their existing sessions are revoked.

8.2 Consent and Privacy

- **FR-5 (MUST):** Before using any feature, a student must view a plain-language notice and give explicit, recorded consent (timestamp, version of the notice).

- **FR-6 (MUST):** Students can withdraw consent, download their data, and request deletion from a Privacy page.
- **FR-7 (MUST):** Deletion requests are honoured with a documented exception: records legally required to be retained (e.g., crisis event logs) are retained in a restricted form **[D3]**. Counsel input is needed on what must be retained.
- **FR-8 (MUST):** Consent for a counsellor to view a student's mood-check-in history is a separate, optional toggle, off by default.

8.3 Counsellor Directory and Booking

- **FR-9 (MUST):** Students see a list of active counsellors at their institution (name, short bio, areas of focus, languages).
- **FR-10 (MUST):** Counsellors define recurring weekly availability and can block specific dates.
- **FR-11 (MUST):** Students book a slot from a counsellor's available times. Double-booking is prevented.
- **FR-12 (MUST):** Students can cancel or reschedule up to a configurable cutoff. **[A2]** Default cutoff: 2 hours before the session.
- **FR-13 (MUST):** Session mode is either in-person (with location text) or online (with a meeting link pasted by the counsellor). **[A3]** ilo does **not** build video calling in the MVP; the counsellor adds an external link.
- **FR-14 (MUST):** Both parties receive email confirmations and a reminder. **[A4]** Reminder is sent 24 hours and 1 hour before.
- **FR-15 (SHOULD):** Counsellors can mark a session as completed, no-show, or cancelled.

8.4 Messaging

- **FR-16 (MUST):** A student can send text messages to a counsellor, and the counsellor can reply, in a one-to-one thread.
- **FR-17 (MUST):** Messages show sent time and read status. Notification emails contain **no message content**, only a prompt to sign in.
- **FR-18 (MUST):** The counsellor sees a single inbox listing threads with unread indicators.
- **FR-19 (MUST):** The UI states clearly that messaging is **not for emergencies** and links to the crisis page.
- **FR-20 (SHOULD):** Counsellors have a stated response window (e.g., replies within 1 working day), configurable per institution.

- **[D4] Message storage architecture.** Your notes mention considering local-first chat (history on each device, encrypted temporary mailbox for offline delivery). **My recommendation for MVP is server-stored messages in Supabase, protected by row-level security and encryption at rest.** Local-first makes multi-device use, counsellor continuity, backups, and crisis review hard, and it is a large engineering effort. Local-first can be a Phase 2 privacy upgrade. Please decide.

8.5 Mood Check-in and Resources

- **FR-21 (MUST):** A student can submit a short check-in (mood scale 1-5, optional tags, optional free-text note). **[A5]** Check-ins are student-initiated; there are no mandatory daily prompts.
- **FR-22 (MUST):** After a check-in, the student sees a short list of relevant resources.
- **FR-23 (MUST):** The Resources section is a static, admin-managed list of articles, links, and helplines grouped by topic (stress, sleep, relationships, career, etc.). **[A6]** Content is authored by ilo and counsellors; no user-generated content.
- **FR-24 (SHOULD):** Students can see a simple trend of their own check-ins over time.
- **[D5] Clinical screening tools.** Using validated instruments (PHQ-9, GAD-7) adds clinical value but also clinical and legal responsibility. **Recommendation: exclude from MVP.** Use the simple mood check-in only. Confirm.

8.6 Crisis Escalation

- **FR-25 (MUST):** A persistent "Need help now?" control is visible on every student screen. It opens a Crisis page showing national and institution-specific helplines and short instructions.
- **FR-26 (MUST):** Helpline numbers are managed by Platform Admin and Institution Admin through a settings field, not hard-coded. **[A7]** Default entry: Tele-MANAS (14416). The agent must flag that numbers need to be verified before launch.
- **FR-27 (MUST):** If a student taps "Alert a counsellor," or a check-in meets the high-risk rule, the system sends an urgent notification (email) to the assigned counsellor, or to a designated on-duty counsellor if none is assigned.
- **FR-28 (MUST):** Crisis events are logged with time, trigger type, who was notified, and outcome notes entered by the counsellor.
- **FR-29 (MUST): [D6] High-risk rule.** Assumption: a check-in is high-risk only if the student selects an explicit "I'm not safe / I'm thinking of harming myself" option. **No automated analysis of free-text in MVP.** Clinical advisor sign-off is required before

launch.

- **FR-30 (MUST):** The system never tells a student that help has definitely been dispatched. It states only that the counsellor has been alerted and shows helplines to use immediately.

8.7 Counsellor Workspace

- **FR-31 (MUST):** Dashboard shows today's appointments, unread messages, and open crisis alerts.
- **FR-32 (MUST):** Student record view shows the student's preferred name, session history, message thread, and (if consented) check-in history.
- **FR-33 (MUST):** Private session notes: free text, tied to a session, visible only to the author counsellor. Notes can be edited for 24 hours and then become append-only. **[A8]**
- **FR-34 (SHOULD):** Counsellor can mark a student as needs follow-up with an optional date.

8.8 Institution Admin Panel

- **FR-35 (MUST):** Admin can invite, deactivate, and reactivate counsellors for their institution.
- **FR-36 (MUST):** Dashboard shows anonymised aggregates: registered students, sessions booked and completed, average time-to-first-appointment, message volume, number of crisis events (count only), and top concern categories.
- **FR-37 (MUST): Small-number suppression:** any aggregate with fewer than 5 people is hidden or shown as "<5" to prevent re-identification.
- **FR-38 (MUST):** Admin can edit institution-level settings: helplines, response-window text, cancellation cutoff, in-person location text.
- **FR-39 (SHOULD):** Admin can export the dashboard summary as CSV or PDF for a selected date range.

8.9 Platform Admin (internal)

- **FR-40 (MUST):** Platform Admin can create an institution, register its email domain(s), and send the first Institution Admin invitation.
- **FR-41 (MUST):** Platform Admin can view system health, aggregate usage per institution, and manage support requests. They **cannot** view messages, notes, or check-ins.

8.10 Notifications

- **FR-42 (MUST):** Email is the only notification channel in the MVP. Types: booking confirmation, reminder, cancellation, new message, crisis alert, invitation.
- **FR-43 (MUST):** Emails never contain sensitive content (no message text, no concern details).

9. Pages and Screens

Public

Screen	Purpose
P1. Landing / Sign-in	Explains ilo briefly; sign-in with institutional email
P2. Check-your-email / verify	Confirms the magic link or OTP step
P3. Privacy Notice and Terms	Plain-language policy, always accessible

Student

Screen	Purpose
S1. Consent and onboarding	First-time consent, preferred name, concern categories
S2. Home	Next appointment, unread messages, quick check-in, Need help now?
S3. Counsellors list	Browse counsellors
S4. Counsellor profile and booking	See bio, pick slot, confirm
S5. My appointments	Upcoming and past; cancel/reschedule
S6. Messages (inbox and thread)	Conversations with counsellor
S7. Mood check-in	Quick entry and trend view
S8. Resources	Browse by topic
S9. Crisis help	Helplines and alert-counsellor action (also a persistent control)

Screen	Purpose
S10. Privacy and data	Consent toggles, download data, delete account
S11. Profile / settings	Name, notification preferences

Counsellor

Screen	Purpose
C1. Dashboard	Today's schedule, unread, crisis alerts
C2. Availability	Weekly hours, blocked dates
C3. Appointments	List with status updates
C4. Inbox and thread	Student messages
C5. Student record	History, check-ins (if consented), notes
C6. Session note editor	Write and view notes
C7. Crisis alert detail	See alert, record outcome
C8. Profile	Bio, focus areas, languages

Institution Admin

Screen	Purpose
A1. Analytics dashboard	Anonymised aggregates and export
A2. Counsellors management	Invite, deactivate
A3. Institution settings	Helplines, cut-offs, location text
A4. Resources management	Add or edit resource entries

Platform Admin

Screen	Purpose
PA1. Institutions	Create institutions, domains, invite first admin

Screen	Purpose
PA2. System overview	Aggregate usage and health

Shared

- 404, 403 (not authorised), session-expired, and maintenance pages.